

Relative clauses

Relative clauses are also known as adjective clauses, and they are a type of subordinate clause. Like adjectives and adjective phrases, relative clauses describe nouns and pronouns. Unlike adjectives, they can only be placed after the noun or pronoun they are modifying. Relative clauses always start with one of the relative pronouns *who*, *whom*, *whose*, *which*, or *that*, which acts as the subject or the object of the clause.

▽ Subject

The relative pronoun *which* is the subject of this relative clause, which describes a noun.



▷ Object

Here, the relative pronoun *which* is the object of the clause—it is receiving the action of the verb *did*.



Adverbial clauses

An adverbial clause is a type of subordinate clause that behaves like an adverb. It gives additional information about how, when, where, and why something is happening. Adverbial clauses start with subordinators such as *because*, *although*, *after*, *while*, *since*, *as*, and *until*.

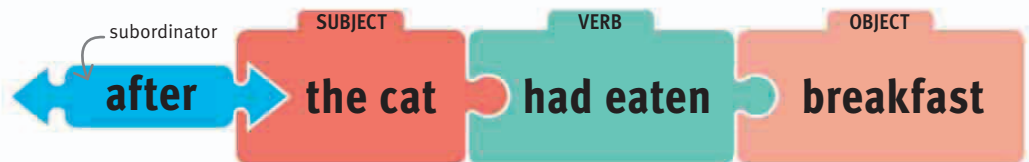
▷ Why?

This adverbial clause explains why the cat did something, but it does not make sense without a main clause.



▷ When?

This adverbial clause explains when the cat did something, but it does not make sense without a main clause.



GLOSSARY

Adverbial phrase A group of words that behave in the same way as an adverb and answer questions such as: How? When? Why? Where? How often?

Object The person or thing that is receiving the verb's action.

Relative pronoun A pronoun that links one part of a sentence to another by introducing a relative clause, which describes an earlier noun or pronoun.

Subject The person or thing that is performing the action.

Subordinator A conjunction used to connect words, phrases, and clauses of unequal importance.

• A **main clause** can be turned into a **subordinate clause** by adding a **subordinator**—for example, “**because** the cat slept.”